BRITISH INFANTRYMAN

Britain has a long history of employing a small professional army to fight varieties of limited war overseas, a tradition that was only temporarily interrupted in the 20th century by the drafting of a mass of conscripts in two world wars. The return to an all-volunteer regular army since the start of the 1960s has thus been in line with British tradition. In other ways, battle has been joined against the army's traditions, with successive reforms of a regimental system widely regarded as outdated, yet stubbornly defended by its adherents.

Up to the 1990s, the post-World War II British Army was chiefly deployed as part of NATO to fight a defensive war against a Soviet invasion of West Germany that never happened, and in a counter-insurgency role in various British-ruled territories, latterly in Northern Ireland. The end of the Cold War, followed by the cessation of the IRA insurgency, naturally led cost-conscious politicians to cut back on infantry numbers in the 1990s. There was also a shift towards higher investment in advanced technology and training for a war of rapid deployment and manoeuvre, in line with American military doctrine.

The British Army contributed the second-largest contingent to the UN forces that drove the Iraqis out of Kuwait in the Gulf War of 1991 – the largest, of course, was supplied by the US. In the early 21st century, the British again supported the US in the invasions of Afghanistan (2001) and Iraq (2003), and the subsequent counter-insurgency campaigns conducted by the occupying forces. The demands of prolonged warfare on this scale severely tested morale and revealed deficiencies in the army's equipment and logistics.

In 2007, the British Army consisted of over 100,000 full-time soldiers, backed up by around 40,000 part-time Territorials. Partly as a result of low unemployment in Britain, there were shortfalls in domestic recruitment, so that an increasing percentage of soldiers came from abroad, mostly from the British Commonwealth. Whether on patrol in Iraq or fighting the Taliban in Afghanistan's Helmand Province, the British infantryman showed himself time and again to be a thorough-going professional.

Desert combat uniform
This British Army combat uniform is a light cotton and polyester mix designed for use in the desert. It was worn by troops in Iraq and Afghanistan in the early 2000s.



SA80 assault rifle
The SA80 is one of only three "bullpup" rifles adopted worldwide; the others are the French FAMAS, and the Austrian AUG. To make the rifle shorter, the action is placed in the butt, with the magazine behind the trigger. This model is the L85A1.